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STATE OF CHANGE

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LIMI-TED RE-LEA-SE

COVID-19 changes the cinematic landscape

BY **ALEXANDRA GALLOWAY**

BLANK MARQUEES GLOW IN THE NIGHT. Theaters sit empty and silent. Sets lay stagnant. Friday nights at the movies, packed to the brim with people clutching popcorn and Slurpees, feel a lifetime away.

From independent movie theaters to massive media conglomerates, COVID-19 has decimated the film industry—crippling production and bringing filmmaking as we know it to a grinding halt. With no decisive end to social distancing in sight, the coronavirus pandemic continues to threaten the livelihoods of hundreds of thousands of industry workers across the United States—all while streaming moguls like Netflix, which gained 16 million subscribers post-lockdown in April, continue to boom. While studios fight to keep up, COVID-19 stands to change the very way we tell stories.

While studios fight to keep up, COVID-19 stands to change the very way we tell stories.

Even before the coronavirus wreaked havoc on the film industry, nights out at the movies were already being cashed in for solitary Netflix binges. Movie audiences are getting older, and studios are abandoning less-profitable genres and investing in safe bets for box office success: superhero franchises, animated features, low-budget horror films, and movies by famous directors like Steven Spielberg and Christopher Nolan. With these trends on a collision course, the film industry has long been on the precipice of change.

"All [COVID-19] has done is taken things that have been gradually transforming the business and put them into work," Greg Johnson '84 SOM—a lecturer at Yale, film producer, and an expert on the business of Hollywood—said in an interview with *The Politic*. "The slow-motion car crash of the theaters has become a full-fledged accident scene—a 50-car pileup."

This past week, Regal Cinemas shut down all of its 536 U.S. locations, furloughing 40,000 workers. Although industry strongholds like Regal and AMC are threatened by debt default and failure, independent theaters have borne the brunt of the pandemic. But the very crowds necessary to revitalize the faltering industry could cause new COVID-19 outbreaks, leaving theaters without the ticket and concession sales that are now their only hope.

To make matters worse, theaters are lacking not only audiences but also new films to showcase. Studios are reluctant to release movies both in theaters and over streaming services, preferring instead to postpone releases until after the pandemic—despite not knowing when it'll end—in hopes of mitigating financial loss.

The September release of Christopher Nolan's recent film *Tenet* only amplified these concerns.

"It just doesn't look like any other Christopher Nolan release in the last 20 years," Johnson said in reference to the film that came out earlier this month. "It dominated the box office to get 20 million on its first weekend. But that's 40 percent of what his comparable movies would do."

Kim Piper '89, an executive producer of the independent film *Phoenix, Oregon*, never expected that in an odd twist of fate, her film would peak at the box offices during COVID-19.

In March, the makers of *Phoenix, Oregon* found themselves at a loss: They wanted people to see their film in theaters, but they did not want to endanger audiences. Instead of pulling their movie, they innovated a solution: "Theatrical-At-Home." The producers still split ticket proceeds 50-50 with theaters but created a digital platform where audiences could enjoy the film on their laptop screens from the comfort of their living rooms.

Because big studios pulled their films from cinemas, *Phoenix, Oregon* was able to top the box office and also show their support for theaters. It also helped the film—a heartwarming indie—receive publicity from major news outlets like *The Washington Post* and *Forbes*.

"It gave us a way to distinguish our film as something different. This is a big-hearted film," Piper said. "We were going to partner with these theaters and say thank you to [them]."

On the brink of shutting down, theaters need loyalty like Piper's now more than ever. If theaters fail, the shockwaves will reverberate through the entire film industry.

"IT MAY EVEN BE WE TELL WILL BE LONG AFTER THIS

AND THIS IS JUST THE BEGINNING: The pandemic has also rendered production nearly impossible—all while the demand for new content has skyrocketed. From shot to clip, filmmakers have reimagined the entire movie-making process to accommodate their new normal.

"Movies with smaller casts that don't require [much] location-scouting or large crowds can be produced as long as they have proper safety protocols in place for sterilizing equipment and social distancing," said Marc Lapadula, a screenwriter and senior lecturer in Film and Media Studies at Yale, in an interview with *The Politic*. But Lapadula predicts that big projects, unless they turn to computerized production methods, will just have to wait.

Documentary filmmaker and Yale fellow Sandra Luckow '87 echoed his concerns. Lucklow is currently filming a documentary entitled *WARNING: DANGER* about Dr. Bandy Lee, the Yale psychiatrist who has openly criticized President Trump's mental fitness for office. COVID-19 has made filming her project much more difficult.

"I can't shoot with a crew; I have to shoot alone; I have to shoot with a mask on all the time [….] It's a whole new world," Lucklow said of her experience in an interview with *The Politic*.

This halt on production has affected filmmaking on every level. It has also put the costumers, set designers, electricians, screenwriters, and actors who depend on the industry for work in dire straits. Actors often supplement their performance income with restaurant work due to its flexible schedule and tips. But with restaurants and bars shuttered during lockdown, this income source has run dry, leaving aspiring movie stars struggling to get by. Without workers to support the industry, the glamour, lights, and drama that make Hollywood special will disappear, too.

"Once upon a time, if [actors] didn't have a job on stage, on screen, or in a commercial, they waited tables in between acting gigs. Now, they don't have either profession to rely on for income," stressed Lapadula.

Some of Lapadula's students who planned to film in Europe had to cancel their plans, while other screenwriting students set to receive payments for their hard work lost that income to the pandemic. Dreams were deferred in an instant.

And yet, despite the way that the film industry has been acutely affected by the pandemic, it has not received much aid from Congress.

"You have theaters that are really begging for relief from Congress and bailouts," said Johnson.

If relief from the government or a COVID-19 vaccine does not come soon, the effects could be deadly for an already-struggling industry. Even if theaters receive aid, whether audiences will come back is unknown.

"Will [the industry] sustain itself? I don't know. Will people revert back to, 'It's pretty easy to sit back and watch it on TV, in my living room, or my television room?'" Lapadula asked. "If that becomes the case, then a lot of these movie theaters are going to just become shells and skeletons: empty spaces where once upon a time people went to movies."

The pandemic has also raised questions as to what stories we tell in film, especially during such profound loss and crisis.

"How do we move forward in this new environment?" asked Lucklow. "Do we want to create content that is specifically COVID-19 related? Do we have love scenes with people [wearing] masks?"

Even though we may see the hallmarks—socially-distant grocery stores and actors clad with face shields—of COVID-19 on the big screen in the imminent future, there may be fundamental changes to the tone and message of movies as well.

"Are there going to be a much more sobering kind of movies in general? Or will they go almost the opposite way, [now] that we've been through so much [that] has been so dark and so challenging?" Lapadula said.

It may even be that the stories we tell will be permanently changed long after this pandemic is over.

"Once a world has experienced

THAT THE STORIES PERMANENTLY CHANGED PANDEMIC IS OVER."

a pandemic, if the scripts are setting the precedent, are they going to have to be rewritten to...deal with the fact that there was this pandemic that now is behind us?" Lapadula asked. "Are [movies] going to pretend they [exist] in a world where there was never a pandemic?"

Even with countless questions still unanswered, Lapadula and Lucklow are certain that the need for art, for stories to be told through film, is greater than ever before. The ability to create art and learn craft is still there, and in it, there is hope.

Student filmmaker Joji Baratelli '24 has continued exploring his passion for film during the pandemic. Growing up in Los Angeles, he was always surrounded by moviemaking and has been making short films since childhood. Because major productions are limiting production staff, Baratelli has been spending his leave of absence shooting music videos and taking on other projects to hone his craft.

"It's been really exciting to be working. It's always been something that was unexpected," Baratelli said in an interview with *The Politic*. "I got one job after another, which I didn't think would happen. It's so unpredictable, so I'm really happy and lucky to be able to be doing things during this time."

EVEN THOUGH COVID-19 has complicated the filmmaking process, Baratelli collaborated with his friends to create an anthology film about lobsters this past June. Starring their family members, Baratelli and his co-filmmakers each shot different segments of the anthology and edited them together to form an entire, cohesive piece. Although they attempted to cast some actors, they had to re-cast due to positive COVID-19 tests, a new vital safety measure during the pandemic. The film *God is a Lobster* was recently selected to be shown at the film festival NFFTY, which will take place over Zoom from October 23 to November 1.

"I'm trying to make a career and a living out of something that I really love and [to find] a way to do it that's still being an artist," he said. Baratelli has tried to not let COVID-19 get in the way of that.

"How lucky are you to find yourself in an unprecedented, historical moment?" Lucklow recalled telling her documentary-making film class this past March. "This is what every documentarian dreams of, and you all are living through it."

She urged her students to create: ousted from Yale, scattered across the country, and armed with their iPhones, they offered beautiful yet heartbreaking windows into what it has been like living through a pandemic.

"[The pandemic] has enabled me to write more than I've ever written," said Lapadula. He encourages other artists to continue their work during the pandemic: "Use limitations, always take an opportunity where [there's] any type of imposed limitations.... How can I make something now, in this moment that I never could have made, had I not been forced to be inspired by these limitations?"

At the end of our interview, Lapadula asked, "Do you know *Waiting for Godot*?"

Then, he began to speak the words of the character Vladimir:

Let us not waste our time in idle discourse! Let us do something, while we have the chance! It is not every day that we are needed. Not indeed that we personally are needed. Others would meet the case equally well, if not better. To all mankind they were addressed, those cries for help still ringing in our ears! But at this place, at this moment of time, all mankind is us, whether we like it or not. Let us make the most of it, before it is too late! Let us represent worthily for once the foul brood to which a cruel fate consigned us! What do you say?

Silence, then:

"That's got to be our answer."

Return to Sender

BY **CAMERON FREEMAN**

Voter suppression and civic engagement as the election nears

ON TUESDAY, JULY 14, Jessie Cheung '24 stood inside a Dallas polling station, checking IDs, updating voter information, and passing out ballots. Despite the dangers of voting amid the COVID-19 crisis, the line stretched far out the door. After two hours of waiting, people were eager to cast their vote in the primary runoff.

This was not Cheung's first time poll working, and she knew the tactics which had led to the long lines at this particular polling location: A group of poll workers had signed up to staff a nearby polling place and not shown up in a concerted effort to suppress voter turnout.

Cheung knew she could make a difference in her community by working at the perennially understaffed polling place.

"Texas is really, really lacking in poll workers," she pointed out in an interview with *The Politic*. "It's up to the younger people to step up." For the past several years, Cheung has sought to fill those shoes and lead her community to register and vote.

But this year, she worries she will not be able to vote herself.

With just weeks until what many consider the most critical election in decades, Yale students from across the country are facing obstacles to voting by mail. Most students have to jump through several hoops to receive a ballot. This will be many students' first time voting absentee—or voting at all. Even with campus civic engagement organizations working overtime, the process to register and request an absentee ballot can be arduous. These difficulties are only magnified by restrictions on mail-in voting implemented in response to the pandemic and ongoing United States Postal Service (USPS) delays.

Even when attempting to vote during non-pandemic years, students living in Yale housing have faced added difficulties. During the 2018 midterms, ballots sent to residential college addresses were returned to sender, leaving many Yalies unable to vote. Though campus groups have worked with the university to rectify past mistakes and provide students with updated resources, memories of those issues remain a cause for concern. This year, USPS delays threaten to disenfranchise students who do not request materials long before Election Day. As voting deadlines loom, many students who began the process months ago have not yet received their ballots. Some fear they never will.

Requiring voters to mail both a physical application and a ballot can serve as an additional barrier for college students, who often lack printers and stamps and rarely use "snail mail." After registering to vote, Cheung embarked on a trying, multi-step process to request an absentee ballot: she and other Texas voters must complete, sign, and mail a ten-part application to the county elections clerk by October 23, 11 days prior to the election. That's assuming they receive one in the first place.

Despite requesting an Application for a Ballot by Mail twice, once in July and again in early August, the clerk's office never confirmed that her requests had been processed, nor did they provide notice that the forms were sent. Neither application arrived.

Eventually, a friend from Texas gave her a spare application, which she mailed to the elections clerk in

"As voting deadlines loom, many students who began the process months ago have not yet received their ballots. Some fear they never will."

mid-September, two months after she first requested the document.

"I'm so excited to vote and feel like I have a say in things," Cheung shared, and then she paused. "But I came to Yale, and there are so many hurdles I have to jump."

FOR CHEUNG, THIS election is about more than just policy: "It's about what America looks like and what America's people want."

Before Cheung moved to Dallas in eighth grade, she knew little about politics. She describes her hometown of Belton—a small, conservative and majority-white town in central Texas—as a "redneck, kind of yee-haw place" where political engagement was rarely discussed.

Likewise, her parents, who immigrated from China to the United States as middle schoolers, never broached the topic.

"They don't know how to vote. They don't know about politics," Cheung said. "How are they supposed to know of something [about which] nothing has been taught to them?"

It wasn't until she moved to Dallas that Cheung first saw the power of the political system and the real consequences of public policy.

"I became aware of a whole new world that impacted me," she remembered. That initial shock has since grown into a passion rooted in responsibility to her community. "I have to be involved, because if I'm not involved, then my family won't be involved."

Still, barriers to voting could prevent even the most enthusiastic voters from casting their ballots. State legislatures across the country, particularly those with Republican majorities like Texas, have repeatedly demurred to make mail-in voting more accessible, even when in-person voting poses a health risk due to COVID-19. Just weeks ago, a federal court rejected a Democratic challenge to the Texas law forbidding in-county absentee voting for citizens under 65. Texas is also one of the 16 states that requires an excuse to vote by mail; despite the pandemic, only voters over 65, disabled, incarcerated, or out of the county on Election Day are eligible to receive absentee ballots.

Meanwhile, at a time when more people will be voting absentee than ever before, ongoing delays with USPS deliveries represent another barrier to mail-in voting. After the appointment of Postmaster General Louis DeJoy in July of 2020, mail delays increased significantly across the country, according to an analysis by *The Upshot* and data published by the USPS.

Over the four weeks between mid-August and mid-September, an average of 46 percent of first-class mail arrived a day late—significantly more than usual. Many of these delays were directly tied to a new rule enacted by DeJoy in July instructing trucks to leave processing facilities on time in the morning, regardless of whether the day's mail is all loaded. The mail left behind is typically not processed until the next day, resulting in increased delays.

Though the USPS has promised to prioritize delivering ballots, such structural changes threaten to increase the delivery times as more voters choose absentee. In states which require a physical ballot to arrive by Election Day, even one-day delays could invalidate thousands of votes.

In the July 2020 primary election, a *Texas Tribune* report showed that 3,010 of 199,218 votes cast by mail across Harris, Tarrant, Bexar, Travis, Collin, Denton, El Paso, Fort Bend, and Hidalgo counties were not counted due to tardiness. With increased strain expected on the USPS during the general election, that number seems likely to rise.

Amidst widespread concern over mail-in voting challenges, prominent politicians—including President Trump—have complained loudly about the potential for election fraud. In July, the president tweeted "Mail-In Ballots will lead to massive electoral fraud and a rigged 2020 Election," though a *Washington Post* analysis revealed only 372 potential cases of fraud among the 14.6 million absentee ballots cast in 2016 and 2018. Some worry that if Americans are convinced that mail-in voting is illegitimate,

the party that loses the election may dispute its outcome.

Conservative politicians have also alluded to another reason for their distrust of mail-in voting. In April, the President tweeted that absentee voting "doesn't work out well for Republicans." Election experts, however, paint a different picture. Though absentee voting does increase turnout, experts suggest that it provides no partisan advantage.

On Thursday, October 1, citing ballot security issues, Texas Governor Greg Abbott decreed a limit of one ballot drop-off location per county. This policy will particularly affect Texans in Democratic strongholds like Harris County, which covers an area larger than Rhode Island and currently boasts 12 ballot drop-off locations. In the court filing that proposed this new limit, Abbott claimed mail-in voting fraud was a "frequent and enduring problem in Texas," despite evidence suggesting it is extremely rare.

"It's not easy for me, and I am, obviously, really, really trying to vote," Cheung lamented. "You would think it would be a lot easier to do it considering it's your 'civic duty.'"

MAIL-IN VOTING has always presented challenges. Social distancing and COVID-19 have only magnified these difficulties as citizens seek out alternative voting methods to avoid Election Day crowds. For populations where mail-in voting is the norm—including college campuses—these problems have long existed.

During the midterm elections in 2018, Yale's Campus Mail Service returned to sender ballots that were sent to residential college addresses, leading to accusations that Yale was disenfranchising students—particularly those who could not afford a 90 -dollar P.O. box. Some students weren't even aware that they were allowed to send absentee ballots to their residential colleges, nor what the protocol was for retrieving them. Some never got their ballots at all.

In 2018, Iman Jaroudi '22 was a first-year student in Trumbull College who spent weeks trying to figure out how to request an absentee ballot for her home state of Kansas.

"I didn't have stamps. I did not know where to buy stamps. I remember asking my Head of College's office, and they were like, 'We don't have stamps yet, but we might get them,'" Jaroudi said in an interview with *The Politic*. "I guess that was the first roadblock. I just physically could not figure out how to send back my application."

Her county election office eventually approved the request. But as of Election Day, her absentee ballot still had not arrived at Trumbull. As she contemplated what to do next, hundreds of Yale students lined up at City Hall for same-day voter registration—only to be informed of a four-hour wait time that jeopardized their ability to vote before polls closed. Jaroudi herself seriously considered a last-ditch effort to vote at City Hall, but decided not to.

"I remember a bunch of people telling me, 'It's still not too late to go! You can register and vote in Connecticut.' But I was really sad because I knew Connecticut was going to go blue," Jaroudi confessed.

"In my home state, we had a very competitive gubernatorial race that year that I really wanted to vote in. And I was like, if I can't vote in my home state's governor's election, I don't even know if I want to vote at all."

The ballot arrived at her residential college the day after the election.

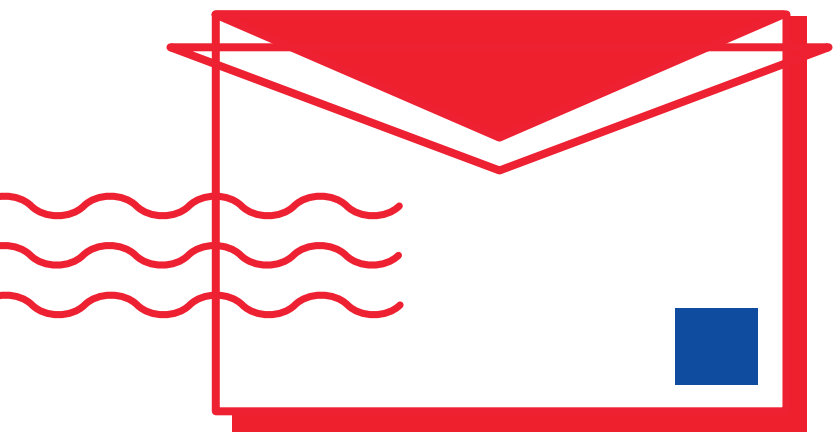
Keeping lessons from the 2018 midterms in mind, Yale Votes and Every Vote Counts (EVC) have led the charge to improve Yale's policies around voting by mail. Jonathan Schwartz '21 helped found EVC, a national student-led nonprofit which began at Yale in 2017 and has since expanded to around 50 colleges and universities. In addition to working as EVC's Director of Voter Engagement, Schwartz also helped create Yale Votes, a nonpartisan coalition of organizations that aim to facilitate voting for students, including the administration, Yale College Council, and Yale College Democrats.

This year, the university promises to ensure that mail-in ballots can be sent to residential Head of Colleges' addresses so that students without P.O. boxes can still receive their ballots. Residential colleges will also be equipped with stamps and envelopes for students.

Yale Votes has also onboarded "state captains" to assist peers with voting absentee; launched a voter-friendly faculty initiative; and created the Yale TurboVote tool for voter registration and ballot requests, which around 1,600 Yale students have used.

In an interview with *The Politic*, Schwartz highlighted the importance of finding new methods to engage with students amid the pandemic, including by bringing faculty into the mission.

"We want to get faculty on board because, especially right now in a remote learning setting, going to class may be someone's strongest connection to the campus culture," he said.



Across Yale, student groups are working to get faculty to lean into the civic component of a liberal arts education. Faculty from a broad variety of departments have emailed students, encouraging them to vote, and Schwartz believes their efforts are making a real difference—yet many question if Yale itself has done enough.

The administration has declined to cancel classes on Election Day, which would not only make it easier for Connecticut-registered Yale students to vote in-person, but could help alleviate local poll worker shortages.

In New Haven and across the country, many veteran poll workers are older and therefore at greater risk of complications from COVID-19. Recruiting younger volunteers, like college students, for in-person election work is critical, but incredibly difficult if those students have class. Polling places are often far from Yale's main campus, presenting a problem both for those who choose to vote in New Haven and those who wish to volunteer.

"It's absurd that Election Day is not a holiday for students," Jaroudi said. "We know that a lot of students are going to be poll workers here in New Haven. We know that a lot of students are going to want to vote in-person here in Connecticut, whether or not they are Connecticut residents."

Students are attempting to reverse the administration's decision on the issue, but with little success.

"It's just crazy to me," Jaroudi continued. "It's crazy that hasn't happened yet."

But there is still reason to be optimistic. There is a pervasive feeling that Yalies are more engaged this year than during previous elections.

"We know how many Yale students are registering to vote and the numbers are really encouraging," Schwartz highlighted.

Cheung has also noticed an increase in civic engagement and excitement among Texas Democrats; according to a recent poll conducted by *The New York Times* and Siena College, President Trump is leading by only three points in Texas. For the first time since 1976, a Democratic presidential nominee has a real chance of winning the state. The momentum moved Cheung to recall how energized voters felt in 2018, when Beto O'Rourke mounted a competitive Senate bid against incumbent Ted Cruz.

"Texas was so close to turning blue," she said. "[O'Rourke] lost by so little, and after that, it was quiet throughout my school for weeks." That race changed things, Cheung added. "So many people showed up, and they now know that showing up matters. They will show up for this presidential election."

Despite the many complications with voting this year, this feeling of momentum—and the years of effort by campus voting organizations—makes Schwartz think more Yale students will vote this year than ever.

"There's a bunch of hurdles, and it's a really difficult process, but we have a great team that tries to work and make it as easy as possible," he explained. "We're very lucky that the administration is pretty open to working with us to make it easy for Yale students to vote."

Jaroudi still mourns her lost opportunity to vote in a midterm election she cared deeply about. She still thinks that Yale should be doing more. Yet she believes that Yale will do better this November than they did two years earlier.

"If there's a silver lining," Jaroudi noted, "I feel very confident that it won't happen again."

SCORCHED EARTH

On Bolsonaro's one-man crusade against environmentalism in Brazil

BY **MARIA ANTONIA SENDAS**



PHOTO COURTESY OF ***O GLOBO***

ALL INTERVIEWS WERE CONDUCTED IN PORTUGUESE AND TRANSLATED INTO ENGLISH BY THE AUTHOR

OUSADO, IN PORTUGUESE, means "daring." When boatmen exploring the Encontro das Águas State Park crossed the São Lourenço River, a tributary of the Paraguay River in the Pantanal region of Brazil, and were approached by a surprisingly tranquil two-year-old male jaguar, they had an opportunity on their hands. Tradition maintains that the first man to catch sight of a jaguar amidst the lush greenery receives the right to its baptizing. So, the boatmen named the jaguar Ousado.

But that was before the fires.

Since July, 77,000 of the Encontro das Águas State Park's 108,000 reserve hectares have been scorched. The burning extends to the entire region of the Pantanal, Brazil's tropical wetland region, where over 2.3 million hectares of land have been damaged—an area ten times the size of São Paulo and Rio de Janeiro combined. The Institute SOS Pantanal estimates that this constitutes over 15 percent of Brazil's biome.

Marina Silva—former Senator of the Brazilian state of Acre, Minister of the Environment in Lula da Silva's administration, and three-time presidential candidate—was born in the small village of Breu Velho, Acre. Raised on a rubber tree plantation where she worked in the fields constructing straw baskets and tapping rubber, Silva and her family lived under a quasi-slavery regime. Though she did not learn to read until she was 16, Silva later went on to help the Brazilian environmentalist Chico Mendes lead Brazil's trade union movement in the 1970s and '80s.

"I remember my childhood in the forest and the people, families, and communities I met," said Silva in an interview with *The Politic*. "People are suffering—precisely those who need nature to live, work, and support their families and the unique character of their own identities."

Reflecting on her upbringing in her home village, Silva recalled that "life in the forest is both fascinating and hard. It is full of beauty and enormous cultural wealth, but also difficult and marked by material poverty."

Her grandmother was a midwife, her mother a seamstress, her father a rubber-tapper, her uncle a surveyor. Each of them relied on the forest for their profession and survival. From her family's dependence on and respect for the landscape and its Indigenous peoples, she learned "the value of solidarity, social ties, mutual aid, and service for the benefit of the community" from a young age.

Yet the land and natural resources that surround and define the lives of countless families like Silva's are in danger.

THE PARAGUAY RIVER cuts through Encontro das Águas and is home to Brazil's jaguar sanctuary, where a team of Brazilian Navy firefighters arrived to rescue Ousado on September 11, 2020. He was no longer the bold, gallant jaguar that the boatmen once knew. Unable to stand, Ousado's paws had been burned on the scorching forest floor. He was taken to a recovery center in Corumbá de Goiás, Brazil where he underwent stem cell therapy to help repair his injured tissue.

But Ousado had better luck than most other jaguars in Encontro das Águas—many didn't survive the flames. Jaguars seek refuge near the river, but the scarcity of water and food imposed by the fires has reduced their chances of survival. The Pantanal, once a land marked by abundance, is now smothered with ash.

The alarming rate of deforestation and the spread of wildfires in the Amazon, the world's largest tropical rainforest, has concerned Brazilian citizens and politicians alike for years. During Silva's tenure in the Lula administration, which obtained national and international recognition for its successes, deforestation in the Amazon fell by 57 percent. More than 1,500 illegal companies practicing deforestation were dismantled, and an additional 500,000 hectares were designated as conservation areas.

Despite efforts by environmentalists like Silva and scientific evidence that the current wildfires are dangerous anomalies that may evolve into long-term patterns, Brazil's president Jair Bolsonaro, a far-right climate skeptic, has ignored the gravity of this environmental disaster. The first anti-environmentalist president of the Federative Republic, Bolsonaro has created an environmental policy agenda marred by denialism and opposition to science.

"I am indignant at the neglect

THE PANTANAL, ONCE A LAND MARKED BY ABUNDANCE, IS NOW SMOTHERED WITH ASH.

SMOTHERED WITH ASH

of others who only care about power, and the greed of others, who only think about their profits," Silva said. "It's a tragedy that biomes so important for life on the planet are under the control of people so irresponsibly uncommitted to it."


PHOTO COURTESY OF ***UNIVERSO ONLINE***

ANDRÉ TRIGUEIRO, a Brazilian environmental journalist and professor at the COPPEAD Graduate School of Business at the Federal University of Rio de Janeiro, believes that every government in the history of Brazil, from different political and ideological currents, has done more wrong than right on the country's environmental agenda.

"The environment has always been seen as the ugly duckling within the esplanade of ministries," Trigueiro told *The Politic*. According to Trigueiro, only President Fernando Collor's demarcation of the Yanomami Indigenous reserve and Silva's administration under Lula stand out as important achievements in the environmental sector: other years have been marred by low budgets and lost fights to the agriculture industry.

But Brazil's tumultuous past with environmental policies pales in comparison to Bolsonaro's negligence. Trigueiro stressed that the current government was the first to adopt a stance of anti-environmentalism. It isn't possible to analyze this administration in relation to others; Bolsonaro's failures go farther than ever before, Trigueiro said.

Before his election in 2018, Bolsonaro defended the elimination of the Ministry of the Environment. The Ministry survived this attack, but Bolsonaro announced that he would, among a multitude of other detrimental actions, alter the rules of the Brazilian Forest Code to benefit rural farmers. This action dissolved the requirement to recompose woods and forests that, combined, "would be the equivalent to twice the size of the state of Sergipe," Trigueiro wrote in *O Globo*. Ultimately, these anti-environmental changes benefited only four percent of rural landowners.

Further, Bolsonaro's current Minister of the Environment Ricardo Salles has been charged with administrative impropriety during his tenure as Secretary of the Environment for São Paulo. Salles illegally changed the rules of an environmental protection area on the Tietê River, east of the city of São Paulo, for the benefit of the Federation of Industries of the State of São Paulo and mining companies.

Salles even suggested that the government take advantage of the media's focus on COVID-19 to "change [environmental] rules and regulations" during a ministerial meeting in April of 2020.

In the face of severe drought and a record increase of wildfires in the Pantanal and the Amazon, the president said Brazil "should be congratulated" for its environmental preservation efforts. He made the statement during the celebratory event for the inauguration of a photovoltaic plant in Paraíba—one day after leaders from eight countries wrote to Bolsonaro warning him


PHOTO COURTESY OF ***UNIVERSO ONLINE***

that deforestation could harm the purchase of Brazilian products.

Trigueiro added that Salles always takes the side of "those who attempt against the environment." He described the Salles administration as "surreal. It is the result of managerial incompetence coupled with bad faith."

ROBERT O. MENDELSOHN, an American economist and the Edwin Weyerhaeuser Professor at the Yale School of the Environment, sought to illuminate the economic motivations underlying Brazilian environmental politics in an interview with *The Politic*.

"Most man-made fires have been set in the Amazon region," Mendelsohn explained. "Brazil has laws against these fires but the new president has made it clear to farmers that he was not going to enforce them."

He clarified that the Amazon, with its hot climates and poor soils, is not well-suited for many sustenance crops. As a result, most farmers in the region raise cattle, resulting in higher methane levels.

"This is a tradeoff between revenues for Brazilian farmers versus conservation of carbon and biodiversity," Mendelsohn explained.

But the world is not yet willing to pay for the high costs of conservation, Mendelsohn said, so the president has encouraged farmers to convert forests into agricultural land. The move aligns with Bolsonaro's broader nationalist platform, best expressed by his "Brazil Before All" campaign slogan.

Another threat of deforestation lies in the region's high real estate value. To Silva, the conversion of the Amazon forests into agricultural and real estate opportunities comes at the cost of thousands of families' survival—families who rely on the land's mangroves and restingas, which are likewise essential for maintaining environmental balance.

Silva characterized the country's environmental policies as "simply a crime: a scorched earth policy."

"It aims to make predatory occupation irreversible, to destroy the possibilities of forest recovery, and to make the land unavailable to communities that depend on the forest environment: Indians, riverside dwellers, *quilombolas* [descendants of Afro-Brazilian slaves], family farmers, extractivists, and fishermen," Silva said.

It is difficult to imagine the consequences of the destruction. In just one month, Silva said, almost 20 percent of the Pantanal was burned. In addition to being one of South America's most important biomes, the Pantanal is also a vital tourist destination, so its destruction will devastate the region's economy for years to come.

It is hard to know how we can make economic sense of the loss of life caused by the fires. While it is easy to conceptualize the losses of market goods because of their set prices, the cost of biodiversity and forest life is invaluable.

"WE HAVE A SUCCESSION of wreckages of Brazilian [environmental] state policy," Trigueiro said—referring to environmental crime impunity, improper allocation of funding toward environmental programs, and crumbling federal environmental agencies. The Brazilian Institute of the Environment and Renewable Natural Resources—the administrative arm of the Ministry of the Environment—is just one of the departments bearing the brunt of the government's environmental rollbacks.

The "solidarity" that Silva described among those who rely on the forest is in stark contrast to the Bolsonaro administration's neglect towards protecting biodiversity and Indigenous populations.

According to Silva, Brazil's political, administrative, economic, and even health and education systems have, for centuries, been guided by a notion of separation—

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rather than integration—of humans and nature. Even political entities that consider themselves progressive are limited to the notion that the environment is an "externality" of economic growth, to be treated as a secondary issue, rather than an integral component of the economy.

As Minister of the Environment, Silva managed to reify sustainable practices and combat environmental crimes, as demonstrated by the creation of over 24 million hectares of protected areas. Yet she had insufficient support from other governmental sectors to move forward with her sustainable development agenda. She proposed that the Ministry of Agriculture become the central ministry for an integrated policy to support sustainable development.

"To understand the logic under which [resource management] works, [one can] look at the difference between the large resources that are destined to finance agribusiness and the much smaller resources that go to family farming, extractivists, and Brazil's Low Carbon Agriculture program," Silva said.

TRIGUEIRO BELIEVES THAT the Bolsonaro administration will eventually be held accountable by the international community for its climate change denialism.

"The obstinacy of this government to persist on this destructive path will cost us dearly in foreign investments, boycott scenarios, and the weakening of the European Union trade agreement with the Mercosur," Trigueiro explained.

From tracking deforestation via satellite imagery to its deforestation reduction goals, Brazil was once a global model for promoting environmentalism, Trigueiro acknowledged. The tragedy, Trigueiro explained, is that the current government is "destroying" Brazil's global contribution to sustainable development.

Silva agrees with this sentiment. She told *The Politic* that the Bolsonaro administration "will not leave behind any legacy or inheritance. All it will create are debts and losses."

"Even if there was a change and the government reversed its anti-environmental[ist] orientation, it would be difficult to recover what we've lost," Silva confessed.

"[We've had] two consecutive years of increased deforestation, fires, land grabbing, invasion of Indigenous lands and protected areas—all kinds of environmental crimes," Silva said. "If we have two more years like this, we'll be at a risk of overcoming the point where entropy becomes dominant and recovery is impossible."

But notwithstanding the incomprehensible environmental destruction Brazil has faced, Silva, the youngest Senator in the history of Brazil, is still dreaming big about Brazil's future.

"My dream is that sustainability will be understood and felt by everyone—not as a concept or an ideology, but as a new way of living and an urgent need for the continuity of human life," Silva mused. "I dream that this will be a shared understanding, superior to political differences. I dream that it will be the basic consensus, a new social pact that will expand to become a natural pact that will include all living beings and ecosystems."

Trigueiro agreed, emphasizing that "environmental destruction should not be treated as an externality, a negligible variable—it should be at the center of our public policies."

In a recent tweet, Silva lamented that while Brazil is a country with "gigantic" natural potential, it is "governed by a president who makes small, irresponsible, and mediocre decisions regarding its protection."

Ousado, who is now resting far away from Encontro das Águas, is slowly healing. "A devastated ecosystem, however," said Silva, "takes hundreds of years to recover."

PLY A CRIME: A
ARTH POLICY



BY **JOSE GUERRERO**


I'm a
Georgia
Voter
I'm a
Georgia
Voter
I'm a

ON NOVEMBER 6, 2018, the nation watched Stacey Abrams LAW '99 narrowly lose to incumbent Brian Kemp in the Georgia gubernatorial election. Her defeat marked the state's closest governor's race since 1966.

Abrams made history as the first Black woman in the nation to be selected as the gubernatorial nominee by a major party. Kemp's tight 1.4 percent victory not only propelled Abrams to national spotlight, but also showcased an increasingly liberal vote begging to crack the surface of a historically Republican stronghold.

Greg Bluestein, political reporter for the *Atlanta Journal-Constitution (AJC)*, remembers Abrams' rise from a "lesser known state lawmaker" to a contender for Joe Biden's 2020 vice presidential pick.

"It was really fascinating…. I went from going to press conferences where I was the only reporter there to events where there were hundreds of reporters, and *The New York Times* was using her name in national headlines," Bluestein said in an interview with *The Politic*.

For Bluestein, a Georgia native who has been covering Georgia politics at *AJC* for over eight years, the 2018 gubernatorial election was a wake-up call: From that moment forward, Georgia politics became anything but predictable.

Bluestein has argued that Abrams' narrow loss was an inflection point for Georgia politics—away from steadfast Republicanism and toward the "purple." In the upcoming election, the Peach State is receiving an unprecedented level of media attention. As of Saturday, October 10, *FiveThirtyEight* polls show Democratic nominee Joe Biden beating President Trump in Georgia by 0.7 points: 47.4 percent to 46.7 percent.

Still, while external polls show Biden and Trump neck-in-neck, the reality on the ground makes it hard for many to believe that Georgia might actually swing blue.

BENTLEY LONG '22 grew up 327 miles away from the *AJC* newsroom in St. Simons, GA. Located in Glynn County, this small coastal town is a popular destination for tourists from all over the state.

In February 2020, a firestorm erupted in Glynn County when Ahmaud Arbery, a 25-year-old Black man, was shot to death by two white men while on a routine jog. Prior to Arbery's murder, most people probably wouldn't have been able to point out rural, conservative Glynn County on a map.

Long vividly recalls the fall of his junior year at Glynn Academy, a public high school in Brunswick, GA where he "saw a lot of love" for Donald Trump. In 2016, Glynn County voted overwhelmingly for Trump, who received 62.47 percent of the vote.

"It was mostly for the shock factor: You wore the red hat and had a MAGA flag hanging from your truck—or perhaps a MAGA chair at the beach," Long said in an interview with *The Politic*, describing conservatives' infatuation with the then-political outsider.

Despite the popular characterization of Trump's base as blue-collar and working class, Long explained, there's an impression in his community that wealth and Republicanism are positively correlated. Thus, lower-income locals explicitly showcase their love for Trump so as to appear wealthier than they actually are.

"The more Republican you are, the more wealthy you are, the more cultural clout you have," Long explained. "It is an odd contrast because simultaneously, these people tend to hate big corporate interests, but they have a strong idolization of the politicians who run those corporate interests."

Despite national polls indicating that Georgia will lean blue in the upcoming presidential election, Long, informed by his high school experience, "does not believe Georgia will vote Democrat in the presidential election."

Back in Atlanta, Professor Alan Abramowitz, the Alben W. Barkley Professor of Political Science at Emory University, has more faith. Abramowitz specializes in elections, voting behavior and public opinion, and election forecasting modeling.

"This year, we're expecting Georgia to be very competitive in the presidential and Senate elections," Abramowitz said in an interview with *The Politic*.

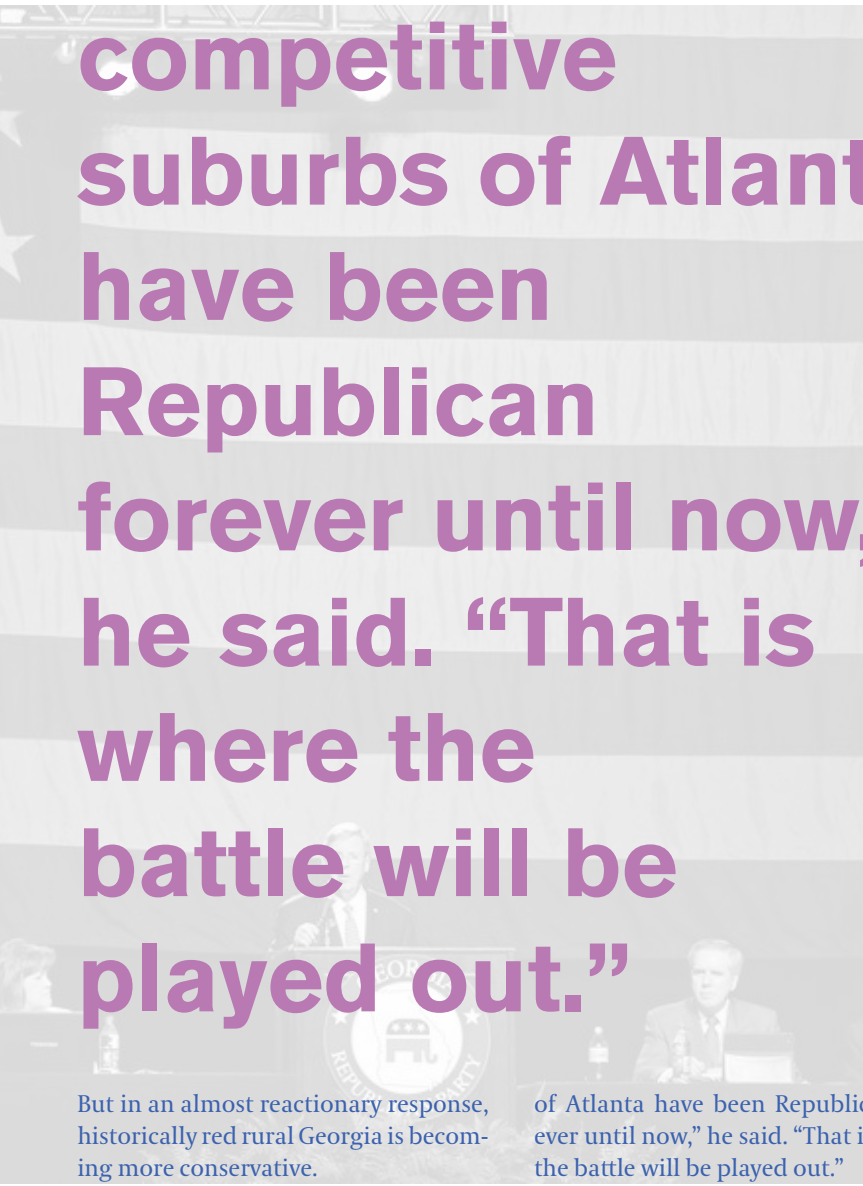
"If you look at small town and rural Georgia, if anything, it has gotten more Republican…except where there are large Black populations," Abramowitz said.

However, the catalyst for Georgia's shift in politics can be explained by changing demographic trends in the state, particularly in Atlanta. Abramowitz detailed how "Metro Atlanta is growing much faster than the rest of the state, and the white population is not growing much at all. The growth in population is coming almost entirely from non-whites," he continued. "Over time, this is contributing to the gradual erosion of the Republican advantage in elections."

According to the Metro Atlanta Chamber, the Atlanta Metropolitan Statistical Area is the ninth largest metro area in the nation, and one of the fastest-growing. From 2010 to 2019, it experienced an increase in population of approximately 734,000 people—the fourth-highest growth rate in the nation. Today, Metro Atlanta has a population of over six million.

As Abramowitz indicated, Atlanta is also a rapidly diversifying city. From 2018 to 2025, estimates from the Georgia Governor's Office of Planning and Budget show a statewide Compound Annual Growth Rate for the white population of 1.11 percent, while the city's Black, Hispanic and other non-white populations are growing at rates of 1.65 percent, 2.66 percent, and 2.59 percent, respectively.

This trend is mirrored in other urban areas outside of Atlanta: cities like Savannah, Augusta, Columbus, and Macon are also beginning to trend Democratic, Abramowitz explained.



“The super competitive suburbs of Atlanta have been Republican forever until now,” he said. “That is where the battle will be played out.”

But in an almost reactionary response, historically red rural Georgia is becoming more conservative.

“The bottom line of the trend [is that] red counties are getting redder. The problem for Republicans is that there are not many more votes in rural counties for Republicans to win,” said Bluestein.

After spending the past few months travelling all over the Peach State to cover the election, Bluestein believes that Democrats will win the Atlanta suburbs. However, he noted that the size of the predicted blue victory margin will be crucial because, as Bluestein explained, “three points in an Atlanta suburb is exponentially different than three points in rural counties.”

“The super competitive suburbs of Atlanta have been Republican forever until now,” he said. “That is where the battle will be played out.”

EMILY, A COLLEGE student in Georgia and former field organizer for the Georgia GOP, emphasized that the Georgia Republican Party has had to transform its strategy in response to the shifting electorate.

“There was this feeling that the GOP had given up in Atlanta, but [we] have a big presence in Buckhead, where the Georgia GOP headquarters are and most of the fundraising within Georgia takes place,” Emily said in an interview with *The Politic*.

Emily detailed that losing former Republican strongholds in Metro Atlanta, especially wealthy areas like Buckhead, has been very worrisome for the Georgia GOP.

“You have very affluent whites who are very Republican and poor whites who are very Republican,” Abramowitz explained. According to Abramowitz, high-income Republicans vote Republican for low taxes and low government spending. In contrast, white low-income voters usually support social security, Medicare, and Medicaid.

“There is a potential problem to Republicans if they appear very hostile to these programs. Republicans have an ongoing effort to overturn the Affordable Care Act, which would actually be very harmful to their own supporters,” Abramowitz explained, puzzled by this dissonance. “But [white low-income voters] do not seem to be aware of that or care much about it to dislodge their preferences.”

“A lot of metro congressional districts that have been safely red before are not anymore and a lot of money, resources and time are being put into these districts,” Emily said. “The big push is for Congressional District 6…. The GOP views this as their last hope for the Atlanta Metro area.”

Unlike the Biden campaign, the GOP has spent a vast amount of resources in Georgia.

“Georgia is an absolutely must-win state for Trump, while for Biden, it is the icing on the cake,” Abramowitz explained. “Biden doesn’t need to win Georgia. If Biden wins Georgia, he almost certainly is winning other swing states.”

According to Bluestein, “In 2016, Trump didn’t visit Georgia in the homestretch. Georgia was a piggy bank for fundraisers, so they didn’t need to bother to spend their time [there].”

But with the Democratic Party now gaining traction in Georgia’s metropolitan areas, “the campaigns are vigorously competing here,” Bluestein said. “Trump was here a few days ago, Pence was here, and there will be more visits in the next few weeks.”

Recently, Republican lawmak-

ers have depended heavily on another strategy to maximize support for Trump.

"Republicans have this problem in shoring up a shrinking base. So, what do you do?" asked Abramowitz.

"You try to maximize support in that base, and then you have to think of ways to suppress turnout in other parts of the state, or at least make it harder to vote."

EVEN AS POLLS indicate that Georgia races are tightening, there is still widespread fear of voter suppression influencing election outcomes. When *AJC* uncovered that thousands of voters in the 2018 gubernatorial election were purged from the database overseen by then-Secretary of State Brian Kemp—who was running in the same election—Georgians suspected corruption.

Alex, a student working with the Georgia Democratic Party, highlighted the urgency of combating voter suppression, especially in a state plagued by the legacy of racist grandfather clauses—laws which required voters to be descendants of Americans who could vote before the the Fifteenth Amendment was ratified.

"Southwestern Georgia, which is majority minority and poor…used to vote Democrat," said Alex. "[But] many of them have been affected by the voter suppression instituted by Brian Kemp and [Brad] Raffisberger." Now, this region consistently votes red and is one of the "driving forces keeping southern Georgia conservative."

Alex noted that from an organizer's perspective, the most significant difference between the 2016 presidential election and that of this year is an increase in resources and investment. They alluded to a motto often used by the Georgia Democratic Party: "Georgia has been blue, but it has not been given the resources to get there."

Now, the Democratic Party of Georgia has its highest number of staff in the state's history and has received investments from the Biden campaign and external sources like Mike Bloomberg.

Georgia Democrats are prioritizing contacting voters of color and low-income voters and providing them with the necessary information they need to vote, Alex noted. They added that "candidates are going directly into low-income neighborhoods, as well as connecting with community leaders."

Long has also noticed a decisive shift within the Republican Party.

"[In the] 2016 election, most Republican support for President Trump, outside of a smaller fanbase, was because he was Republican, or because of a strong dislike of Hillary Clinton," Long said.

Now, Long explains that a vote for "Trump is a vote for Trump"—rather than voting against the opposition, Republicans are actively voting for the president. Long noted how distrust in the media has driven support for President Trump, leading to further polarization. "Now, if you don't get your news from Fox News…it's fake, and if they say something negative on Fox News, it's fake."

"[This] media bubble doesn't coincide with reality," Long explained. "There are whole towns and churches and school districts where a majority of people only get their news from one source that reaffirms the current administration. They are only exposed to that—only making them more right."

Emily remembers a time in her GOP field organizing days when an older woman complained to her about Fox News at a GOP event. To Emily's surprise, the lady quipped that "[Fox is] just too liberal; I prefer to watch One America News."

"They are really just nitpicking their news," Emily said. "They just want to see the good and will not look at the bad, all they want to do is excuse [Trump's] behavior and move on."

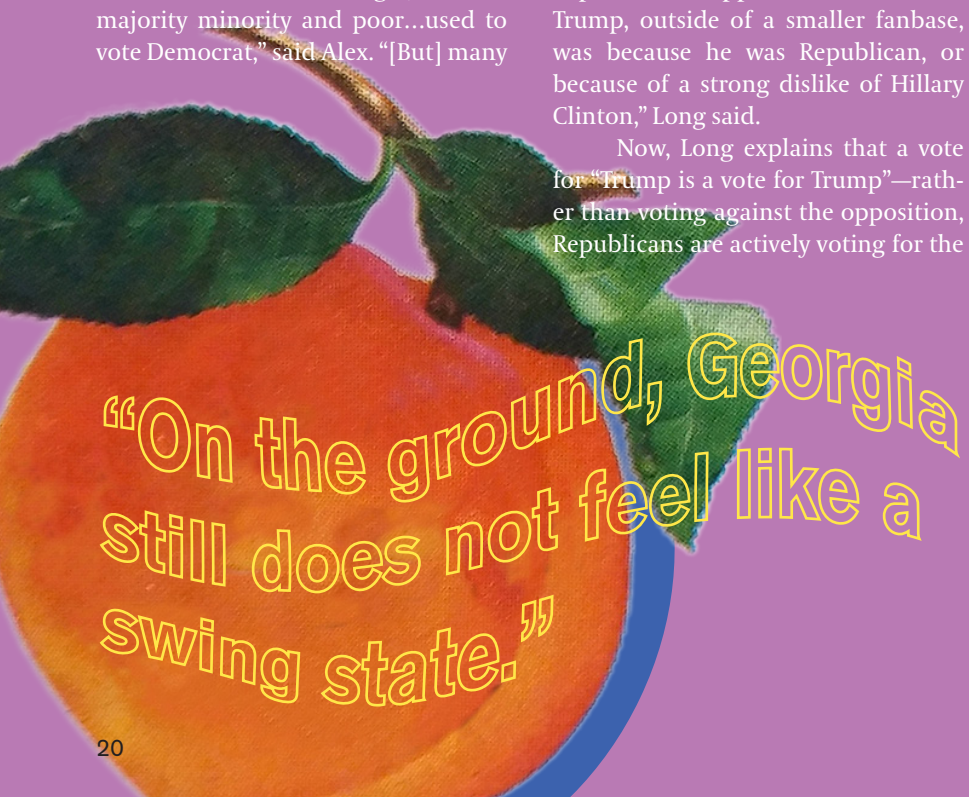
She highlighted that this was a common encounter. Even if internal party data projects that the GOP will lose Georgia by an estimated one-point margin, Georgia Republicans will not believe it.

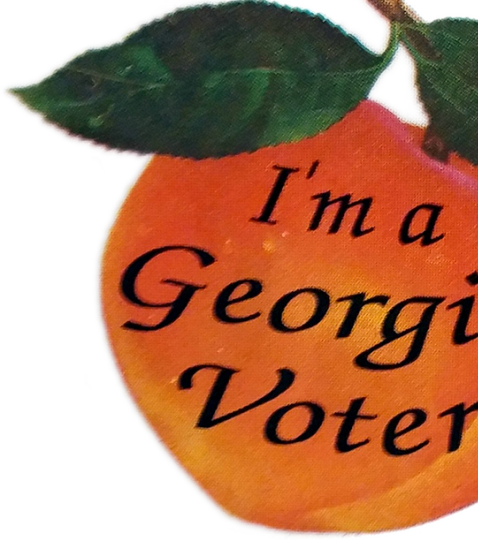
On the ground, Georgia still does not feel like a swing state.

THE CORE OF GEORGIA'S turbulent politics can be attributed to the polarization of hotly contested social problems, some of which are the sole determining factor for single-issue voters, leaving little room for Democrats to seize undecided votes.

Abramowitz explained that these cultural issues often directly correlate to voters' religious beliefs, leading to increased support for President Trump, particularly from less-educated white voters.

"A significant percentage of the [Georgia] population is white evangelicals—some of the strongest supporters of Trump," Abramowitz said. "They feel threatened: They feel like their





values are being threatened. They are particularly concerned about abortion."

To Long, the Republican Party's large base in Georgia is due to its victories on the issues of gun control and abortion.

"If you fundamentally believe that abortion is murder, your morals will not allow you to vote for anyone who says it's okay that abortion is okay," Long said.

Because of these extreme viewpoints, he believes that there is a large base of Georgia voters, predominately comprised of evangelicals, who will never budge on abortion, and therefore will never budge from their side of the political aisle.

However, Long believes that gun control may be a more approachable issue for Democrats, though they have failed to beat Republican marketing thus far.

"Republicans have made it so that in the public conscience of the South...any law regarding guns is labeled as control," Long explained. "That wording—'control'—is huge in the Republican ideology. Any reference to gun legislation is a direct opposition to the Second Amendment."

From this, Long credits Republicans in "winning the battle in understanding how people's minds work."

"The Republicans are the best psychologists in America," he continued. "This is why they brand conception as the beginning of life and any type of gun control as the antithesis of the Second Amendment."

For Emily, however, the Republican reliance on these social issues is creating a divide within the Republican Party, particularly between younger and older generations.

"You have the Christian right, they are a huge portion of the Republican Party," but now, there are more "young Republicans who care about the LGBTQ+ community, that care about racial equality and climate change, that are pro-choice, but they still hold small government beliefs," Emily said.

These are precisely the voters the Biden campaign is targeting in a concerted effort to swing Georgia blue.

And this is why Emily is concerned about the GOP's future. She knows that the Republican Party needs to rebrand and demonstrate that they care about issues important to younger voters. However, the question remains if the party can, or will.

"There are things that should not be a partisan issue: The Republican response [to police brutality] should not be that 'blue lives matter.' The response should be: 'We need to talk about this,'" Emily lamented.

Such frustrating responses have made it extremely hard for Emily to continue working with the GOP—especially in the aftermath of the injustices against Arbery, George Floyd, Breonna Taylor, and countless others—even as she finds Republican principles like "small government and personal freedom" important.

Emily believes that the Republican Party is at a critical point in its existence.

"Who do they want to represent the Republican Party? What do they want to be associated with?" Emily asked. "With Trump, you have seen the rise of candidates like Marjorie Taylor Greene or even Brian Kemp: Is this going to be their legacy? Or will they move back in the opposite direction?"

On the other side of the aisle, Georgia's Democrats are optimistic. Alex believes that Georgia will swing blue by 2028, if not sooner.

"Stacey Abrams showed that you can win Georgia in a way that has not been tried before," they argued. "Historically, the party continually ran white moderates as if they were going to win by rebuilding the Democratic Party of the '70s, '80s, and '90s in the South."

But as calls for gender and racial equality intensify, the Democratic Party is trying to keep up. The outcome of the 2020 general election will prove whether or not it is capable of doing so.

The Right to Dignity



BY **VANIKA MAHESH**

On Wednesday, September 9, Marta Shcharbakova spent the night staring at the four walls of her cell inside of Akrescina prison in Belarus.

"I knew it was dangerous before I went to the protest," she told *The Politic*, "but someone had to go."

Experiences like this one are not uncommon in Belarus, often dubbed "Europe's last dictatorship." When President Alexander Lukashenko was re-elected to his sixth term in office on August 9 of this year, it incited a wave of protests across the nation. Shcharbakova is one of thousands of Belarussians who have taken to the streets to demand the end of Lukashenko's 26-year regime.

For Shcharbakova, who has been actively involved in protests against the regime for the last seven years, this revolution has been a long time coming. Ulyana Schkel, a friend and classmate of Shcharbakova's, described how "as soon as the protests started, [Shcharbakova] was like, 'I have to be there. I have to be in that space because that's what we were fighting for our entire life."

The two of them were studying abroad together at Bennington College in Bennington, VT until Shcharbakova left for Belarus midway through her studies to join the protests.

Now back with her mother and sister at home, Shcharbakova echoes

courtesy of the Associated Press News



A feminist revolution in Europe's last dictatorship

this sentiment.

"I don't see how I could forgive myself if I stayed away. My heart was lighter in jail than it was in the safety of the United States," she admitted. Shcharbakova now only hopes for a successful trial, explaining, "If I don't get bail, I might have to miss even more classes."

Shcharbakova is not alone in her courage. Every weekend since the elections, protesters have flooded the streets of Minsk chanting for the resignation of Lukashenko—or "the cockroach," as they call him—and demanding their right to free and fair elections. The government's mismanagement of the COVID-19 pandemic has only fueled protesters' fire. Despite more than 450 documented cases of torture and ill-treatment of detainees and at least seven deaths in the two months since the election, Belarussians across the country have sparked a democratic revolution that has yet to reach its crescendo.

DEMOCRACY, HOWEVER, will not be achieved easily. For almost as long as Belarus has existed as a nation, it has been under Russian rule, whether formally or informally. From 1795 to 1918, Belarus was a part of the Russian empire, and after a brief stint of independence during World War I, it was quickly absorbed into the Soviet



Union and remained a republic of the USSR until 1991. Independent Belarus will only celebrate its 30th birthday next year, and Lukashenko—a dictator sympathetic to Russia—has ruled for the last 26 of those years.

Born into a poor family in 1954, Lukashenko served in the Soviet military, later joined the ranks of the Communist Party, and was eventually promoted to deputy chairman of the collective farms. Lukashenko is a product of Soviet Union ideology, and citizens note that his policies reflect that.

"I'm not sure to what extent Lukashenko even considers himself Belarussian," said Orel Bellinson, a Ph.D. student of European and Russian history at Yale University, in an interview with *The Politic*. Schekl's nonchalance in questioning Lukashenko's loyalties—citing his "mediocre" command over the Belarussian language—belies widespread discontent among citizens.

Given the dictator's profound ties to the USSR, few were surprised that one of his first moves after his election in 1994 was to propose a union of the Slavic states between Russia and Belarus, a goal he eventually achieved in 1999. And in May 1995, he issued a referendum declaring Russian an official language of Belarus and replacing the country's flag with one that bore Soviet colors instead.

Lukashenko's domestic policy of Russification has transformed Belarus over the past two decades.

"Only six percent of Belarussians speak Belarusian," Schkel said. Her entire family now only speaks Russian. Aggressive Russification both during the Russian empire and the USSR combined with the regime's preference for Russian in official settings has made it difficult for Belarusian to take hold even post-independence.

"Russian is the language of government organizations and schools. We have incredible Belarusian poetry, we have beautiful songs, and all of that has been shoved under the carpet." According to Schkel, Belarusian has been relegated to the language of counter-culture and political opposition. To speak Belarusian has now become "a political act."

Centuries of foreign rule have made it very difficult for Belarussians to develop a shared national identity. If they speak Russian, share in Russian history, and are culturally homogenous, what makes Belarus a nation-state in its own right?

This is a question Bellinson ponders. These protests, he believes, are really a cry for independence. In his eyes, this is Belarus' real chance to leave the Soviet Union behind.

> "The regime lost ground, and civil society gained it."

A CITIZEN-LED revolution demanding both democracy and independence was long overdue.

Dr. Aliaksei Kazharski, a Belarussian political scientist currently based in Slovenia, emphasized the grassroots nature of these mass protests.

"The protests are not led by the traditional opposition leaders or by the new opposition leaders that have emerged after this election," he explained in an interview with *The Politic*. "Instead, they are coordinated through Telegram, a social media messaging app."

For a revolution of this scale, a lack of organized leadership is uncommon.

Lukashenko has jailed or exiled the three female leaders at the forefront of this movement—Svetlana Tikhanovskaya, Veronika Tespkalo, and Maria Kolesnikova. Yet as Tikhanovskaya herself asserts to the local press, "we are only symbols." The decentralized essence of these protests has made it incredibly difficult for the regime to quell the revolution from the top down.

This kind of organizational structure is only possible due to the recent visibility of modern technology. The rise of social media has undermined the regime's long-held monopoly over information, and deprived of this classic authoritarian tool, Lukashenko's regime has finally begun to show some cracks.

Angelina Makretsova, a first-year student at the University of Richmond studying remotely in Belarus, explained that social media has played a crucial role as an alternate source of information for everyday Belarussians, who previously could only turn to state-run television propaganda for news.

"Before, when [Lukashenko] would kill the opposition leader, no one would know. But now, whatever happens, we know straight away," Makretsova said in an interview with *The Politic*. "And this is why the anger piles up, because we saw what happened to our people in detention centers. How they were raped with police batons, how severely beaten they were, how they were dying in there."

After watching something like that, "you cannot stop protesting," said Makretsova.

For this newfound transparency, Belarussians perhaps have COVID-19 to thank. The virus has compelled more than just teenagers to turn to social media. Sławomir Sierakowski, the founder of Polish left-wing intellectual movement Krytyka Polityczna and a senior fellow at the German Council on Foreign Relations, described that the pandemic, "which Lukashenko completely bungled," sowed distrust in governmental competence. As a result, people turned away from state or Russian newspapers and began relying on social media for less censored news sources.

"At first, [Lukashenko] said that [COVID-19] did not exist. There was no lockdown in Belarus, and little of anything that could pass for state policy regarding the virus," Sierakowski said. When people began to die, Lukashenko ordered news outlets to hide the grim statistics. He told his people to simply "drink vodka" and "work in the fields."

COVID-19 was more than just a catalyst for the replacement of state media with alternative news sources: It also provided an opportunity to expose the regime's corruption in its entirety.

When Lukashenko shirked his responsibilities, Belarussians had to step up themselves. According to Sierakowski, "citizens began banding together to buy masks and equipment, to help the sick, and to assist medical personnel."

Lukashenko's hands-off approach to the pandemic meant that the virus spread rapidly, infecting more than 60,000 Belarussians, an official statistic that likely underestimated the real number of infections. If the dictator had reached somewhat of an "equilibrium," as Bellinson puts it, in his 26-year regime, this betrayal of the social contract—his refusal to provide basic healthcare necessities—had broken it.

For Shcharbakova, this was when any semblance of credibility the regime had left was lost. People "really saw all those ambulances and all those dead bodies," she said. "You can't make another narrative about what is happening before you. That was eye-opening for many people."

As Sierakowski put it, "the regime lost ground, and civil society gained it."

Fast forward to the August elections and, for the first time, there were viable opposition candidates and an informed civil society ready for change. The impact of the coronavirus had forced even ordinary Belarussians to confront the failures of their government.

"People were tired," said Scharbakova. Had Lukashenko recognized this, explained Bellinson, he perhaps would not have been so indifferent to his people's concerns and disrespectful towards an election that had already inspired popular enthusiasm across the country.

"What was so upsetting about this time is not even that Lukashenko stole the election," because it was obvious that he would, Bellinson said. "But the way he so cynically did so broke all hell loose."

According to official statistics from the government, Lukashenko received 80 percent of the votes, while only 6 percent went to the primary opposition candidate, Svetlana Tikhanovskaya, and the remaining 14 percent chose not to vote.

"It would have been different," Orel believes, "if Lukashenko had at least admitted that it was a close fight. Instead, he made it look like more people chose not to vote than vote for [Tikhanovskaya], which was obviously wrong."

For Belarussians, this blatant lie was enough indication that Lukashenko did not even acknowledge the humanity of his people. And so began a revolution of dignity, or *hidnist*, as the Ukrainians call it.

MARCI SHORE, YALE professor and author of *The Ukranian Night: An Intimate History of Revolution*, described the protests as "an explosion of civil society." In written correspondence with *The Politic*, she painted this revolution as "a magical moment of solidarity."

"Strangers find another on the street, help one another, people can count on another," she continued. "It is a sudden sense of not only empowerment, where ordinary people realize they can do a lot by organizing themselves, but also of care for one another."

"Magical" is indeed the right word to describe these protests; not only have they remained consistently peaceful in the face of violent government crackdowns, but many see a certain beauty in their methods.

The first notable characteristic of the protests is that they are primarily female-driven. Tikhanovskaya, Tespkalo, and Kolesnikova stepped in to lead the presidential campaign and the activist movement when their own husbands were targeted and imprisoned by the regime. Further, protestors have been organizing women's marches every Saturday, where wives, daughters, and sisters take to the streets to protest the regime's use of violence against protesters. From the top down, this is truly a feminist revolution and, according to Shore, the first of its kind in Europe.

Makretsova, who attended the women's marches with her mother,

described "huge numbers of women wearing white and with flowers all across the city." These all-female marches were originally launched to draw attention to the regime's unlawful detentions and police brutality, especially in the first few days after the election, a time now referred to as the "wave of terror." Now they have morphed into weekly displays of solidarity, acting as a stark contrast to Lukashenko's brutality.

Shcharbakova explained that Lukashenko's "underestimation of women" made them the ideal protesters. Gender roles in Belarus are so deeply ingrained that although police officers will detain men, "it is understood that you do not touch a woman," Scharbakova pointed out.

Illustrating an image of social cohesion, she continued, "women support men by coming to protest for them and men support women. They give them a ride, take them home, and bring them food and water."

This mutual solidarity has transformed the nation, Kazharski explained. "A new civil society is being born in Belarus," he said. "People go outside, they cook, they share food, they listen to music, and organize."

For Kazharski, another "magical" characteristic of the protests is the phenomenon of "aesthetic resistance." The red and white colors of the original independent Belarussian flag have become a symbol of opposition to Lukashenko, present everywhere from parades of women marching for peace to the clothing choices of everyday Belarussians. Murals and artwork dot the city in these very same colors, and women have even begun to hang up their underwear in alternating patterns of red and white.

While Lukashenko's henchmen have been tasked with "fighting the flag," there is only so much they can do to police a clothesline. In transforming the urban landscape this way, Belarussians have won an aesthetic hegemony against Lukashenko.

The protests tell a "magical" tale of the Belarussian spirit. But some still fear the impending geopolitical consequences of this revolution.

RUSSIA'S IMPORTANCE to Belarus' history, coupled with Lukashenko's affinity for the country, elevates the two nations' relationship beyond that of traditional allies. In an interview with *The Politic*, Dr. Kazharski characterised the rapport as a "soap opera that has been playing between Minsk and Moscow for decades."

This dynamic has complicated the question of Russian interference in the escalating revolution.

Putin is, at best, a reluctant supporter of Lukashenko, who has more than once "gotten on his nerves," according to Kazharski. But his dislike for Lukashenko pales in comparison to his phobia of democratic revolutions and the possibility of an European Union or NATO-allied state in his backyard. Putin needs Belarus to act as a barrier to prevent NATO troops on his border, pushing him to continuously prop up the regime. However, says Kazharski, "I don't think Moscow is prepared to pay Lukashenko's bills indefinitely."

Sierakowski and many of the world's experts in the region agree. Belarus is certain to be an expensive project, and allying with the nation could potentially incite the wrath of both the E.U. and the United States.

Still, despite clear potential for foreign intervention and the power play between the U.S., Russia, and the E.U. to influence these protests, the fate of this revolution will ultimately be determined by the Belarussian people and their leader.

Even without Moscow's continued support, Lukashenko is unlikely to step down. On September 23, in a ceremony only announced after it had already taken place, Lukashenko was secretly inaugurated as president.

The protesters, however, have not given up. Both in physical demonstrations on the streets and through the magical aesthetic transformation of Belarussian society, the revolution continues. Each time the regime has flexed its muscles in a show of violence and power, Belarussians have responded with even more peaceful protests—a testament to the incredible resilience of humanity and the power of collective action. It is in the flags hanging from apartment windows and the stripes of red and white on crosswalks and doorways that this revolution lives on.

"There are more of us, and we will not stop fighting," their graffiti art seems to say.



STILL TOGETHER*

* How a summer of protest could lead to lasting change at Yale

BY **DAEVAN MANGALMURTI**

While the Yale clubs and campus groups that donated and called for systemic change this summer haven't gone silent, levels of activity on racial justice have descended from their summer highs.

"THE REASON...I WANTED TO BE ON BOARD WAS TO HELP MAKE THESE CHANGES."

That's how Eda Uzunlar '22 described her perspective towards institutional reform within the Yale International Relations Association (YIRA), which bills itself as Yale's largest undergraduate organization. Uzunlar ran to be YIRA's Vice President in Spring 2020, driven by the feeling that the organization could be doing more to implement long-discussed policy changes in response to racial and economic inequalities at Yale and across the United States. She took office in May expecting the process to be a gradual one.

In a single protest-filled week this past June, it became clear to Uzunlar, among others, that gradual change would not be enough. On Monday, May 25, George Floyd, a 49-year-old Black resident of Minneapolis, was murdered by Derek Chauvin, an officer of the Minneapolis Police Department.

Together with dozens of Yale student groups, YIRA launched into action. The organization's June 2020 Instagram feed offered statements on racism and equality, calls for donations to civil rights groups, and promises to raise money for racial justice causes.

On Tuesday, June 2, the Yale College Council (YCC) organized Yale Together, a fundraiser pooling Yale clubs' resources to support five Black and Indigenous community organizations. Backed by more than 80 Yale groups compelled by a need to act—including YIRA—the initiative raised $57,715.

Over three months have passed since Yale Together stopped accepting donations in early July. While the Yale clubs and campus groups that donated and called for systemic change this summer haven't gone silent, levels of activity on racial justice have descended from their summer highs.

Across Yale's campus, student organizations are faced with a quandary. Cultural and social associations, recreational clubs, and Greek life were mostly established as gathering places for people with similar backgrounds and interests—not with political concerns in mind.

SHORTLY AFTER the murder of Floyd—coming within a few months of those of Ahmaud Arbery, Breonna Taylor, and Tony McDade—Kahlil Greene '21, former YCC President and a primary organizer of Yale Together, knew he needed to take action.

But the realities of systemic inequality has required student groups to take on more overtly "political" stances in support of social justice. As the personal becomes political, how are they approaching this challenge?

"I came up with the idea for Yale Together when brainstorming a response to George Floyd's murder with the executive board of the Yale College Council," Greene told *The Politic* in an email. "I saw many organizations making statements, and when asked if the YCC should do the same, I said, 'We need to do something more substantial.'"

Although he appreciated the impact of statements and pledges, Greene thought it especially important to enact actionable change by donating money and resources to communities in need.

"We realized that our own funds wouldn't amount to much impact alone, so to multiply our giving, I came up with a streamlined process for other student groups to also give money and resources directly to nonprofits and community organizations," Greene explained.

"And so, the movement was born."

Operating remotely, Greene and other YCC members organized countless group chats, Zoom meetings, and Google Doc editing sessions with Yale club leaders as they worked to launch Yale Together. Greene and his team chose five organizations—based in New Haven, Minneapolis, and nationally—to direct donations to: the Black Visions Collective, the Connecticut Bail Fund, Black Lives Matter, the Navajo & Hopi Families COVID Relief Fund, and the Greater New Haven COVID Community Fund. In choosing the organizations, Greene placed an emphasis on sourcing input from representatives of Yale's Black student groups, as well as from Dwight Hall.

Greene noted that "there was obviously a wave of social pressure that may have motivated a lot of otherwise indifferent people and organizations to support the Black Lives Matter movement this summer."

"However," he continued, "we will see if, once that vigor dissipates, these clubs continue to take action in favor of protecting Black people from police violence and combating deeply set racial injustice."

TRANSLATING SUMMERTIME PROMISES to continuous action on racial justice has been at the front of Iman Iftikhar '23's mind this year. Iftikhar, who serves as the Political Action Chair for the Yale South Asian Society (SAS), spent the summer at home in Pakistan. With limited avenues for direct action on American racial justice issues where she was, she began compiling resources for South Asian students wanting to support Black liberation causes in the U.S. soon after Floyd's murder.

"South Asians for Black Lives," now a 16-page-long document, includes a pledge from 28 South Asian student organizations across the U.S. to fight for racial justice and against anti-Black racism in the South Asian community.

The challenge?

"People signed on, but we don't really know what that commitment looks like," Iftikhar said in an interview with *The Politic*.

In the aftermath of Floyd's murder, Yale Political Union (YPU) President Jeff Cieslikowski '22 faced a challenge very different from Iftikhar's. He and the Speaker of the YPU, McKinsey Crozier '22, wanted to use their positions to make a statement on racial justice—without committing all of the YPU with them.

The YPU has an odd position among Yale clubs: It is both highly political and highly decentralized. Its seven political parties, which cover most of the political spectrum, come together for weekly debates under YPU auspices. Otherwise, they operate autonomously, making it difficult for the YPU's leadership to claim to represent the organization as a cohesive whole.

The "Message of Solidarity" Cieslikowski and Crozier released in June reflected the nature of their organization. It encouraged donations to racial justice organizations, self-education on anti-racism, and support for protesters. But it came only from the two of them.

"When we released this message, we weren't speaking on behalf of the Union. We weren't speaking on behalf of the parties," Cieslikowski explained in an interview with *The Politic*. "We were simply speaking as President and Speaker, as individuals who are in a position—not on behalf of the Union."

In Iftikhar's case, the SAS as a whole has committed to material action on racial justice. But that doesn't mean every member is equally engaged with the issue. Iftikhar has set up an antiracist book club, is planning an October teach-in on South Asian organizing on campus, and has helped SAS join Black Students for Disarmament at Yale (BSDY) as a member organization. All these actions fit into the open-ended promises made in SAS's pledge to be actively anti-racist. But Iftikhar still has concerns.

"I will be very, very honest: Our wider group's commitment to the cause has decreased," she said.

"SAS isn't inherently a political group," continued Iftikhar. "I think people's understanding of SAS has been that it's a cultural, social organization that does dance... that highlights South Asian culture, but not necessarily politics."

For the YPU, where "political" is in the very name of the organization, students join for the express purpose of debating their views and political beliefs. But Cieslikowski sees the YPU's commitment to issues of racial justice as an intellectual, rather than activist, commitment.

"The themes of racial inequality are a topic that we discuss and that we debate and think about frequently—how we can go about reforming it, what good strategies would be," he said.

Cieslikowski reiterated several times that the YPU is centered on intellectual growth and debate, maintaining that "we weren't saying that the Political Union is going to take steps to encourage [protesting]" in its solidarity statement.

"Our goal as the Political Union," he explained, is "not to necessarily say, 'go out and be an activist,' but to say that 'these are the things that you should think about and that you should clarify for yourself so that you can go out and be an activist.'"

"For a group like SAS, at least, there needs to be a re-evaluation of our values," Iftikhar argued. "What does it mean for SAS to suddenly be political? What does it mean for SAS to be an ally?"

The differences between the YPU's belief in debate rather than protest and Iftikhar's efforts to encourage activism within SAS illustrate Yale organizations' diverse approaches towards addressing racial justice. There's no one-size-fits-all approach, and many organizations are still determining how to act.

AS THE SUMMER'S early days of round-the-clock protests and constant media attention to racial justice initiatives began to fade, Uzunlar said that YIRA's Board of Directors kept discussing what they could do to go beyond "performative" actions and fundraising.

YIRA contributed 2,000 dollars to Yale Together in June, and Siddarth Shankar '22, YIRA's Treasurer, reported that it also raised 10,020 dollars (independent of Yale Together) via a corporate matching program. But the organization's Board wanted to figure out how to sustain the summer's momentum into the school year.

"We've been having these ideas in our head for a while of how we can do different things to better the YIRA culture [and] better how we have our official transactions with the community and the community outside of Yale," Uzunlar said of the Board's thought process.

The Board's conversations culminated in YIRA's Institutional Change Project, a forty-point list of nine policies and thirty-one "best practices" intended to address systemic issues and inequality at YIRA. The items on the list touch on everything from YIRA's recruitment process (which is now anonymous to prevent unconscious bias), to using Google Forms instead of Word Documents (to improve accessibility), to simplifying the acronyms of YIRA's various Model United Nations conferences.

YIRA's beginning-of-the-year recruitment process, which took place in September 2020, was the first test of the Institutional Change Project.

"It's gone really well so far," Uzunlar said. But she sees many of the changes—like a project to work with YIRA's alumni network to introduce stipends for students holding leadership positions at YIRA's conferences—taking far longer than a month to pull together and enact successfully.

When asked about the plethora of pledges to act on racial justice made by clubs in the wake of the summer's protests, Uzunlar drew from YIRA's experience to offer words of caution.

"It's easy to get caught up and think that sometimes if you don't implement 'this idea' first, someone else will—which isn't good," she said. "It really does help to think

"I will be very, very honest: Our wider group's commitment to the cause has decreased."

thoroughly through things, especially when they'll have realistic consequences."

Uzunlar is optimistic, though, about the potential for meaningful systemic change at Yale. "I think everyone probably has the best intentions always."

WHILE ORGANIZATIONS focused on cultural, political, and international affairs may be naturally drawn to race equity issues, Yale organizations outside those realms have also reevaluated their purposes in light of recent events. Racial justice and activism are most likely not the first things that come to mind when the Yale Entrepreneurial Society (YES) is mentioned. YES Co-President Brihu Sundararaman '23 knows that.

"Systemic racism, especially in the entrepreneurship-slash-venture capital world, is not talked about a lot, but the numbers don't lie," Sundararaman said in an interview with *The Politic*. According to the mission statement for YES's Amplify speaker series, Black entrepreneurs received only one percent of venture capital funding in 2018, even though 63 percent of Black Americans are interested in starting a business.

Amplify, which took place this summer, was one of YES's first steps in embracing increased action on racial justice. A ten-week series focusing on the experience of "underrepresented minorities" in venture capital, it was hosted in concert with eight other national universities and nine historically Black colleges and universities (HBCUs). The series was pitched as both a chance to learn from Black entrepreneurs and as a small fundraiser for five organizations encouraging Black representation in business and entrepreneurship. The initiative raised 910 dollars for those organizations.

While YES plans to host events like Amplify in the future, Sundararaman said it's currently exploring other ways of creating what he repeatedly called a more "inclusive" environment.

"In our application," Sundararaman explained, "we are trying to actually make sure that we can hold ourselves accountable by asking people: 'If you're comfortable, would you mind sharing your background?'"

The goal, he said, is to use the organization's Fall 2020 data as a baseline for how and where YES needs to improve in terms of diversity and inclusion, and to continue tracking application information as a guard against bias in interviews and recruitment processes.

"You can't really make a change," Sundararaman explained, "unless you have the data to say, 'We need to make a change,' or 'We are improving.'"

The data collected by YES so far show that the demographic breakdown of accepted YES members this year was as follows: 66.2 percent Asian, 23.9 percent Caucasian, 5.7 percent Black/African American, 2.8 percent Hispanic, and 1.4 percent Middle Eastern.

For comparison, Yale's student body breakdown for non-international students in 2019 was 15.3 percent Asian, 41.6 percent White, 6.1 percent Black/African American, 10.5 percent Hispanic, and 0.4 percent American Indian/Alaska Native/Native Hawaiian/Pacific Islander. The University does not collect data on Middle Eastern students as a separate ethnicity.

"For us, these numbers represent a first step in holding ourselves accountable but also, hopefully, as an example for our fellow organizations to do the same," Sundararaman said in an email correspondence with *The Politic*. "Compared to Yale's undergraduate diversity, we believe this fall is a good initial step but know we have a lot of work to do in making entrepreneurship inclusive."

That's a point Greene would agree with: "Yale student organizations definitely need to increase pathways for underrepresented student groups to access both membership and leadership within their clubs."

Informed by both its efforts this summer and the recruitment data it collected, Sundararaman said YES is planning events with HBCUs, "fireside chats" with a more diverse group of Yale-affiliated startup founders, and partnerships with the Black Student Alliance at Yale and Sube, the Yale Latinx Business and Leadership Student Association, this fall. It's also introducing anonymous feedback forms for its members.

As YES plans for the future, Sundararaman doesn't see the desire to effect change in the organization, and in reducing barriers to access in entrepreneurship, going anywhere.

"'We opened our eyes and then we closed them again' will not be YES's attitude to racial justice," said Sundararaman."That is not acceptable. When we are preparing the next round of leadership, [we will] make it very, explicitly clear: This is the new YES."

AS THE DAYS tick down to what promises to be a historic presidential election, racial justice issues have not lost their relevance for many Americans. Yale students are no different.

According to a *Yale Daily News* survey of the Class of 2024, about 90 percent of respondents were "somewhat" or "very much supportive" of Black Lives Matter and protests against police brutality. Aliesa Bahri '22 and Reilly Johnson '22, the newly-elected YCC President and Vice President, respectively, campaigned on a platform that included a 19-point list of racial justice action items covering issues such as faculty diversity, mental health services for people of color, and defunding the Yale Police Department.

Greene hopes that a new era has dawned for the YCC—and for Yale as a whole.

"I hope that my legacy is that of awakening a social conscience within Yale's student government," he said.

While the extent to which Bahri and Johnson actually follow through on their campaign pledges remains to be seen, it does seem that Yale student organizations are embracing the legacy of Yale Together. Whether they continue to do so has yet to be seen.

Enthusiasm for action on racial justice is already waning on the national level, and Yale is not immune to those trends. Clubs are returning to routines, students have other things to occupy their minds, and attention spans can be all too short. There is a danger that racial justice commitments fall by the wayside.

But lasting, systemic change is not made in a day. As Iftikhar points out:

"It's a long-term commitment."

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In Claudia Rankine's *Just Us*, a call for conversation

BY **NICK JACOBSON**

"IS SHE GOING TO ask me?" I wondered before I sat down for an interview with Professor Claudia Rankine. "Is she going to ask me how I, a white man, understand my privilege?"

I had just finished Rankine's newest book, *Just Us: An American Conversation*, a collection of essays and poetry. The first essay, "liminal spaces i," centers around Rankine's hesitant desire to ask white men that very question. I was not sure how I would respond.

When Rankine picked up the phone, a few minutes after she responded to my email request and a half hour before she was supposed to appear on National Public Radio, Rankine did not ask me her question, and I did not volunteer an

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answer. I wondered if I might have disappointed her.

That fear of mine—that my questions might have been misguided and my responses unfitting—arose from reading Rankine's candid, personal questions about race and racism, and finding myself without answers. In *Just Us*, Rankine, a Black woman, examines race through dialogue, trying to pin down exactly its role in her life and in our country. She challenges us to enter into her discussion, to scrutinize our own lives in the light of her accounts.

By focusing her attention on small, intimate conversations, Rankine passes by the calls for popular uprising that have swept millions of people onto the streets across the nation. Her worries and confessions are never extracted from the personal experiences from which she draws: she resists universalizing the discussion she engages into a political agenda or a roadmap to progress.

Instead, Rankine demands that we ask again what race and racism do to our lives even when others (including, sometimes, myself) wonder whether we had better act first and ask second. As she takes time to reflect amidst the chaos and violence of our world, I found Rankine trying to talk to me.

Rankine's essays, all written in the first person, tackle questions of racial inequity from her unvarnished experience.

"This book is about my conversations, specific people in my life or people that I have approached who are strangers," Rankine told me. In one essay, Rankine recalls talking to a white man whose son was not accepted early to Yale.

"It's tough when you can't play the diversity card," he said. Immediately, we read her unspoken responses: "Was he yanking my chain?.... Should I have asked how he knew a person of color 'took' his son's seat and not another white son of one of these many white men sitting around us?"

Reading Rankine's questions, I thought again about how the privileges of being a white man who also happens to be Jewish and from rural Pennsylvania (do those count as "diversity cards?") factored into my own admission to Yale.

While we witness Rankine's conversations in her essays, the poems in the work speak directly to us. They are Rankine's opportunity to ask each of us, in her words, "what is getting in the way of [our] conversations." The first lines of the book read:

> What does it mean to want
> an age-old call
> for change
> not to change
>
> and yet, also,
> to feel bullied
> by the call to change?

The question does not propel us toward a single answer. Instead, Rankine conjures the fear, anger, and yearning that surround change, perhaps with the hope that by clarifying the resistance to and the desire for newness, we might find a way to respond to her.

Rankine's questions do demand answers; they are the ones we have tried to answer time and time again, unsatisfactorily. When I read these lines, I thought of my hometown, the swastikas and profanity that recently marred the intersections of our main highway, and I felt Rankine's unfulfilled longing even while I struggled to see a way to realize it.

Together, her essays and the poetry reconstruct the unity—the "we"—in our country and our lives. Rankine's "I" often finds herself alienated from an imagined "we." While talking to a white female friend, Rankine casually comments on their similar economic status, but regrets the comment immediately.

She writes, "I'm stalled by the thought that I have no inherited wealth; I didn't have a choice about whether to work outside the home while raising my child as my friend did, and, and…."

The "we" that she referenced in her comment to her friend does not exist, at least not how she conceived it, so she recants it. Yet how to account for the unity in their friendship? Rankine asks, "If similarity and sameness are essentially impossible, how is 'difference' recouped and aligned with closeness?"

The reconciliation comes by reconstructing a "we" that "allows us to fall away from the ease of intimacy without falling…the two-step, just us, no, you and I." Rankine thus reforges a "we" that encompasses difference without fracturing beneath its weight.

What if that "we" is fantastical? That question haunts Rankine throughout the text. Even after she rights the misstated connection with her friend, Rankine must confess that she does not know how her friend really feels about the moment. In the book, when Rankine's white friends are put to the test, they too often back down from discomfort at the pivotal moment.

A glance at this month's headlines only deepens my doubt about forging a new "we" in this country. One of the police officers that broke into Breonna Taylor's house and murdered her was charged with endangering her neighbors; President Trump refused to commit to a peaceful transfer of power—or any transfer at all; after the Republican Senate majority refused to confirm a Supreme Court Justice in the final year of Obama's presidency, 51 Republican Senators announced that they will break that precedent without hesitation (43 of them were in office in 2015).

Near my home in Pennsylvania, police officers murdered a Black man and then arrested medics as they tended to protesters whom the officers had tear gassed. These were the headlines for the week of Monday, September 28. There is no indication that such tragedies will abate any time soon. In the face of these events, I worry that the call to conversation that Rankine labeled as "the very heart of the book" falls on too many deaf ears.

Yet here I am, doing my best to continue her conversation. I wonder if I am doing it wrong. I worry because I am partaking in and reinforcing the limits of our world in the most elite academic (not to mention economic, political, etc.) circle in America, if not many parts of the globe.

The book's title, *Just Us*, troubles me when I imagine it circulating through our closed institutions.

Whatever is
being expressed, what if,
I am here awaiting, waiting for you
in the what if, in the questions,
in the conditionals,
in the imperatives—what if.

By coming to a place like Yale, by reading (and writing for) one of Yale's magazines, we commit to sustained, rich discussion as an imperative for our world, even though that discussion is located in small or explicitly closed venues.

I will return to Yale to speak with people about the burning issues of racism and inequality, among others. I will do that in no small part because I believe that our discussions—though limited—are important. I will also return to Yale with lingering doubt. We cannot always be talking, or perhaps better, we should not, especially not just amongst ourselves.

Rankine herself is not absolved of these questions. Given the all-encompassing topic of conversation, that Rankine's own work does not include everyone is inevitable. Her descriptions of elite universities' admissions processes, her art critiques, and even her various discussions on airplanes reflect her own orientation to her subject. Rankine herself immigrated from Jamaica as a child, but in *Just Us*, she focuses on only the past three years of her life.

Given this positionality, Rankine cannot always directly address some of my own questions about my home in rural Pennsylvania and the hatred, fear, and longing that festers there. But Rankine did not write *Just Us* as a manual to revitalize our nation. As much as the book is a guide to understanding each other, it is also Rankine's reflection on her own experience.

Rankine said to me, "*Just Us* could be a memoir in a certain way, but narrowly focused on conversations." When her friend told her that her book had "no strategy," Rankine replied, "response is my strategy...to forfeit the ability to attempt again, to converse again, to speak with, to question and to listen to, is to be complicit with the violence of an unchanging structure contending with the aliveness and constant movement of all of us."

Rankine's strategy is not a strategy for everyone. She knows of the desperate need for immediate change in the foundations of our country, and that discourse is insufficient for that project.

The first thing Rankine said to me was, "I have often wondered what it was like in 1933 Germany. It's crazy." November's election weighs heavily on her shoulders. Nonetheless, Rankine wants to think outside November, outside every crucial consecutive moment that consumes our lives. She insists that conversation ought to be someone's strategy—that it ought to be hers.

Rankine will not relinquish her hope for newness, for an answer that we have not yet found but still might. In the opening poems of the book, titled "what if," she writes:

> Whatever is
> being expressed, what if,
> I am here awaiting, waiting for you
> in the what if, in the questions,
> in the conditionals,
> in the imperatives—what if.

When we talked, Rankine described herself imagining "what it would mean to have something new, a new sentence in response to my questions." Rankine shows the depth of her fortitude and faith, her willingness not only to participate in but actively to seek out exchanges that range from unsettling to downright painful in search of that one new sentence.

By the end of our conversation and her book, I did not have that sentence for Rankine, but I had begun to suspect that she might be looking for a joke. It would be wrong to call *Just Us* funny. It is not. Yet humor surfaces and resurfaces, a motif hovering just around the edges of the text. Rankine discusses bad jokes—what mostly white teachers called a scenario in which a student compares a carving of a Black person to a "monkey"—and bitter laughter—how she erupts upon hearing a white colleague tell her, "I've been doing antiracist work since the '80s. I'm here to tell you it makes no difference."

While we spoke, we laughed about nothing funny at all: Hitler's rise to power, Trump's equivocations after Heather Heyer's murder in Charlottesville. Our laughter gave voice to the things that words could not, another kind of "two-step," perhaps, acknowledging the wrongs that cannot be righted without succumbing to them.

The joke that Rankine seeks is not funny, or, if it is, it has a kind of humor that magnifies communication rather than reducing it, that works to acknowledge and elevate the impossibility of verbal expression rather than brushing it aside. When I asked Rankine about the role that humor plays in the world today, she said (after complimenting the "Trevor Noahs of the world") that humor is "another way of creating discourse... another way of creating connection and intimacy."

As example, she referenced Dave Chappelle's special after the murder of George Floyd, "8:46," calling it "a sharing of recognition, a sharing of the absurdity and violence and mourning that has determined our present lives, our present world." This sharing through laughter might open a door to a kind of unity that we lack as a people right now. Though Rankine's humor offers us neither escape nor unearned comfort, perhaps it does offer something new.

Claudia Rankine wrote *Just Us: An American Conversation* about talking to people, questioning people, laughing with people. Reading it, each of us gets a chance to talk to her, too, to unsettle our lives and to enter them anew. The book is a portrait of Rankine—her life, her thoughts, her identity—but it, too, is a mirror, so that to gaze upon her face, you must confront the faint reflection of your own, staring back.

Mr. Scaramucci Goes to Washington

An Interview with President Trump's Former Communications Director

BY **TIMOTHY HAN**

Anthony Scaramucci is a former White House Communications Director for President Trump. The following transcript has been edited for length and clarity.

SOMETHING I DIDN'T KNOW ABOUT YOU IS THAT YOU'VE BEEN INVOLVED IN A NUMBER OF DIFFERENT CAMPAIGNS. IN 2008, YOU SUPPORTED HILLARY CLINTON AND BARACK OBAMA.

SCARAMUCCI: I probably gave over $150,000 to Barack Obama in 2008. And Secretary Clinton, that was really just for a friend of mine who wanted me to help her.

[BUT] IN 2012, YOU WORKED AS THE NATIONAL FINANCE CO-CHAIR FOR GOVERNOR ROMNEY RUNNING AGAINST PRESIDENT OBAMA. WHAT CHANGED YOUR MIND ABOUT OBAMA?

I just realized that what he was doing was probably not best for me and my business. And so I sort of returned to my Republican roots—nothing personal.

IN APRIL 2012 YOU SAID [OF SENATOR CLINTON]: "I HOPE SHE RUNS. SHE'S INCREDIBLY COMPETENT. I LIKE HILLARY: YOU HAVE TO GO WITH THE BEST ATHLETE. WE NEED TO TURN THIS AROUND." BUT BY 2015, YOU'RE WORKING FOR GOVERNOR WALKER. WHAT CHANGED YOUR MIND ABOUT SECRETARY CLINTON?

Yeah. I just, I'm a lifelong Republican. So I went with the Republican. You should do the opposite of what I do. Okay? I typically have been dead wrong about all my political choices.

NOW ABOUT THE PRESIDENT. AFTER WORKING FOR GOVERNOR WALKER AND FOR GOVERNOR BUSH IN THE 2016 PRIMARIES, YOU JOINED THE TRUMP CAMPAIGN FINANCE TEAM. THE *WASHINGTON POST* CALLED YOU "ONE OF THE FIRST TRADITIONAL REPUBLICANS TO SUPPORT THE PRESIDENT." YOU GAVE $200,000 TO THE RNC, $100,000 TO REBUILDING AMERICA PAC, $150,000 TO THE TRUMP VICTORY FUND. YOU WERE ON THE EXECUTIVE COMMITTEE OF THE TRUMP TRANSITION TEAM. YOU REPRESENTED THEM AT DAVOS. SO WHAT APPEALED TO YOU ABOUT THE PRESIDENT BACK THEN?

That's my bed. I have to own all that. Because it was a mistake. You know, he didn't handle himself the way we want. We thought he was capable of. You have two choices in our system, right? And I'm a Republican. And so I went with the Republican choice. I didn't think that he was going to act like that.

DO YOU REGRET ACCEPTING THE ROLE OF WHITE HOUSE COMMUNICATIONS DIRECTOR?

I wouldn't do it again, if given the chance, knowing what I know. It was a very surreal experience for me. I got an 11-day PhD in Washington scumbaggery. I mean, I have a better idea of how these people operate now, and what they're really all about, and how they really don't give a shit about the American people.

DO YOU EVER HAVE ASPIRATIONS FOR PUBLIC OFFICE? COULD WE EVER SEE CONGRESSMAN SCARAMUCCI?

No, I'm not suited for it. I don't have the personality for it. Having said that, I'm not a politician. So I don't want to say, 'You'll never see me go back to Washington,' and then in six months, I'm in Washington. Like, okay, typical jerko politician, so I don't know. I like making money. I like bullshitting with you. But if you're going to attack my family on the Presidential Twitter feed, I'm coming guns blazing.

YOU'RE NOT TED CRUZ.

I'm not Ted Cruz. I'm an Italian kid from Long Island. So you want to attack my wife on the Presidential Twitter feed? We're going to be in a bloodsport cage match.

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